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ARENA OF HEALTH

# The Group Benefits of Mindfulness Meditation in Education and Mental Health Care

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## Abstract

In mindfulness practice, psychological sciences have been representing a core premise for multidisciplinary efforts. Research has been undertaken to explain how mindfulness meditation plays its beneficial impact on physical and mental health, as well as to study the effects on cognitive performance and emotional regulation in a variety of educational settings. Although mindfulness meditation shares common principles with other psychological interventions, such as acceptance and empathy, a specific focus on relational aspects and sense of belonging remains uncertain. The practice of mindfulness provides a potential framework by supporting individuals in the research of meanings, whereas mindfulness-based groups encourage social interactions between practitioners as part of the training sessions. This article will review mindfulness group interventions based on mindfulness group membership, whilst a sense of belonging through mindfulness will be referred to emerging prospects in individual practice. It follows that mindfulness intervention models are being offered to promote psychological well-being in terms of learning requirements and group membership.

**Keywords** Mindfulness · Group membership · Sense of belonging · Social interactions

In a large body of literature, the mindfulness-based cognitive approach has been mainly interpreted to attain a better understanding of the relationship between mind and brain (Fletcher et al. 2010; Hölzel et al. 2011; Siegel 2012) and to treat symptoms of anxiety (Goldin and Gross 2010; Hofmann et al. 2010) and depression (Segal et al. 2013; Teasdale et al. 2000), among a wider spectrum of mental health issues (Hayes 2004; Singh et al. 2008) and other medical conditions (Grossman et al. 2004).

Sustaining a focused attention of one's own body-mind involves mechanisms of self-regulation (Bishop et al. 2004) and human response to stimuli (Langer 1992). Mindfulness is a well-known secular teaching practice, which engages practitioners to learn through

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practice, by focusing attention on present and taking a non-judgemental attitude (Hayes and Wilson 2003; Kabat-Zinn 2003). Learning mindfulness is indeed a process which repeatedly takes place in a peer group (Grossman et al. 2004; Visted et al. 2015). In addition, mindfulness-based training programmes require participants to perform regular home practice (Parsons et al. 2017).

Whether the critical role of group processes in mindfulness-based group interventions appears relevant (Cormack et al. 2018), the main focus of this article is to outline relational aspects of mindfulness practice and its impact on psychological well-being (Brown and Ryan 2003).

In particular, current research has been focusing on individual features (Davidson and Kaszniak 2015) that would make mindfulness meditation effective and efficient in cognitive-behavioural therapy (Singh et al. 2008). Similarly, behavioural practices of mindfulness have been exploring breathing techniques to elicit emotional regulation processes (Arch and Craske 2006).

According to the above perspectives, research studies on cognitive and emotional benefits have not comprehensively examined the effects of individual's attendance to mindfulness groups. This would include environmental opportunities for taking in-training roles, along with mindfulness group membership and relationships between practitioners and instructor. Overall, the group benefits of mindfulness have been highlighted in education and mental health care, whereby group was part of either training or treatment.

## The Role of Mindfulness-Based Group

Mindfulness group membership is being developed through the attendance to regular classes (Visted et al. 2015) and long-term opportunities of shared practice. Group sessions refer to the underlying principles of mindfulness teaching philosophy (Piet et al. 2016) and focus on benefits of group practice, in order to connect experienced members and newcomers with a learning community (Byrnes and Caron 2019).

Although the effectiveness of mindfulness in clinical practice warrants further methodological research (Goldberg et al. 2018; Gotink et al. 2015; Hedman-Lagerlöf et al. 2018), social support and sense of belonging (Lambert et al. 2013; Ma 2003) among mindfulness community learners would reveal the occurrence of recurrent social interactions resulting from group practice (Cormack et al. 2018). In the happening of group sessions, practitioners receive a mutual feedback from peers and describe their own home practice to instructors in an open and timely manner. Whether building working alliance in a less-structured environment would be an asset (Jazaieri et al. 2018), mindfulness-based groups are promising to offer traditional modelling and social meanings similarly to other group therapies (Forsyth 2010). In relation to this, mindfulness group membership would combine individual and group practice with a sense of belonging, through influential processes that facilitate the experience of learning mindfulness within a group, as well as the fulfilment of home practice (Fig. 1).

## Mindfulness for Education and Mental Health Care Settings

Both the significance of attending school and the development of social and emotional competence, including the achievement of cognitive milestones, have been traditionally a psychological research issue in childhood and adolescence. There is a broad consensus that child development and education would benefit from the cultivation of life skills (World

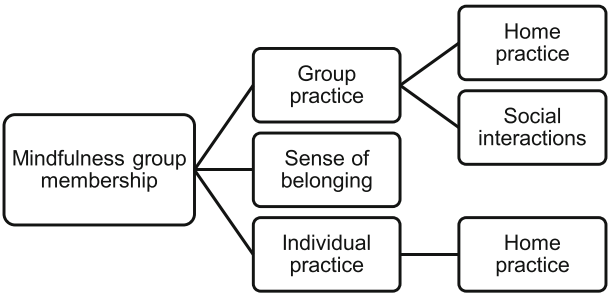


**Fig. 1** A model of mindfulness group membership

Health Organization 2003). Similarly, the requirements of teaching mindfulness would engage teachers with the demands of life practice (Piet et al. 2016).

It is believed that school age is when children and adolescents acquire more complex skills, regarding their own social competence and through social relationships with peers and teachers (Urdan and Schoenfelder 2006). As a result, mindfulness groups would be one of the possibilities to improve course syllabus and to prepare future educators (Roeser et al. 2012). One related argument for this is that training to mindfulness has been transferred to develop dimensions of mindful parenting and parents have been trained to mindfulness behaviours (Duncan et al. 2009). In particular, mindfulness applied to education has been delivered through both group training for school-aged children and teachers, as well as classroom training in adolescence (Meiklejohn et al. 2012).

Application of mindfulness in educational settings would provide insights on group activities (Carsley et al. 2015) and classroom management (Jennings 2015), promoting psychological well-being (Huppert and Johnson 2010; Waters 2011) and uncovering social meanings related to being mindful in different cultures (Kirmayer 2015). Based on this, mindfulness trainings in education have been providing a preliminary evidence across different age groups (Burke 2010; Schonert-Reichl and Lawlor 2010). There is a growing number of structured educational programmes based on mindfulness, including implementation studies in school settings (Zenner et al. 2014).

If mindfulness would take its own place in life-skills education, it appears likewise unprejudiced. However, mindfulness studies have been producing cognitive evidence through group-based interventions (Visted et al. 2015). On the other hand, home practice of mindfulness would provide practitioners a model of self-determination (Niemiec and Ryan 2009), in terms of health promotion (Brown and Ryan 2003), teacher competences and classroom outcomes (Jennings and Greenberg 2009). Nevertheless, school-based mindfulness is still in its infancy and this represents a major challenge to policymakers and teaching professionals for developing tailored school programmes (Greenberg and Harris 2012).

Currently in clinical practice, mindfulness-based interventions have been used in mental health care (Gu et al. 2015), as supported by evidence across a broad spectrum of clinical conditions and within health care settings (Shapiro and Carlson 2017). In particular, interventions based on mindfulness practice have been investigated by referring to heterogeneous criteria, whilst structured training programmes were also group taught (Grossman et al. 2004). Promoting mindfulness has widely been considered a turning point for researchers and clinicians involved in transposing the Buddhist roots of mindfulness into research prospects (Hayes and Feldman 2004; Langer 1992; Kabat-Zinn 2003).

## Promoting Mindfulness in an Interconnected World

Over recent decades, it has given rise to doubts how social media technology extended our understanding of social ties (Kawachi and Berkman 2001), affecting individual engagement in real-life conversations and sharing ideas with others across traditional boundaries (Baym 2009).

If one accepts that building long-term relationships with others represents a critical milestone in the child development, a significant absence of others is likewise related to challenges on education and health (Haslam et al. 2018).

Why would mindfulness be more beneficial to improve psychological well-being and how could mindfulness training help to overcome communication barriers in real-life settings? In a virtual context, mindfulness training programmes have been delivered through websites and guided online classrooms (Spijkerman et al. 2016).

As an alternative to face-to-face interactions, online mindfulness programmes would reveal difficulties to define social presence (Lowenthal and Snelson 2017) and limitations to the delivery mode of online classes. In online training environments, individual learning would benefit from social meanings of teaching (Armellini and De Stefani 2016), and reflect quality of social interactions rather than quantity between peers and teacher (Tu and McIsaac 2002).

Whether individuals interact in real-life or virtual settings, shared practice would serve as a model for mindfulness meditation to bring social interactions among practitioners in the context of a daily commitment to practice (Kabat-Zinn 2003). Above all, mindfulness experience would support group participants to establish and maintain social interactions, as well as to benefit from formal and informal practice.

## Future Perspectives in Mindfulness Research

It seems plausible that the roles mindfulness-based group has on learning outcomes of trainees typically depends on home practice (Parsons et al. 2017) and teacher training (Piet et al. 2016; Roeser et al. 2012). The clinical implementation of group interventions refers to a separate scope of mindfulness in mental health care, including personal engagement of therapist (Singh et al. 2008) and implications on working alliance (Jazaieri et al. 2018).

The other side of social interactions in mindfulness group interventions appears underestimated. Nevertheless, the group of practitioners has been representing a breeding ground to deliver mindfulness-based interventions and to develop mindfulness-based programmes at schools. Therefore, mindfulness practice would promote a major need of belonging and enable social interactions between individual learners. Based on this approach, psychological theories should encompass mindfulness meditation, as the happening of community learning (Byrnes and Caron 2019) and group membership.

In general, mindfulness-based groups can form a basis for developing and shaping psychological interventions, whereby researching the process of individual change towards social relationships (Umberson and Montez 2010; Siegel 2012). Further implications from a sense of belonging would bring mindfulness to combine social interactions with individual and group practice. This would provide practitioners new opportunities to develop cognitive and emotional competence in a peer group. Overall, the study of social interactions would be likely to add new information on the health benefits of mindfulness in clinical and non-clinical populations. Individual and group practice together would show that group practice on its own also refers to prerequisites for learning mindfulness and its ancient roots.

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